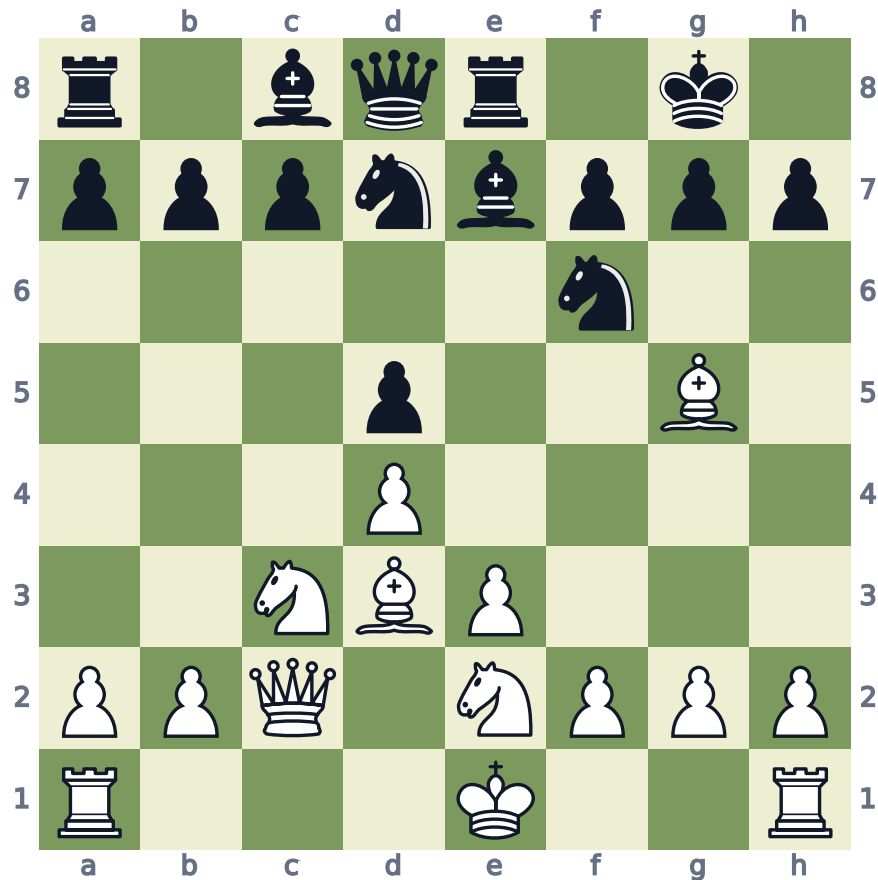


Queen's Gambit Declined Repertoire

The Exchange Variation, Ragozin ideas, Tarrasch structures, and minority play



Meet the Queen's Gambit Declined with an understandable Exchange-based repertoire while learning the freeing breaks and counterplans Black needs.

8 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Meet the Queen's Gambit Declined with an understandable Exchange-based repertoire while learning the freeing breaks and counterplans Black needs.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
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WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure.

PRINCIPLE 2

Nge2 often supports f3 and e4 without blocking the f-pawn.

PRINCIPLE 3

The minority attack uses b4-b5 to create a target on c6.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Black's ...c5 and ...e5 breaks matter more than passive pawn defense.

PRINCIPLE 5

A bishop pin changes central tactics only while the pin is real.

PRINCIPLE 6

Move orders decide whether Black gets ...Bf5, ...Bb4, or ...c5 comfortably.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

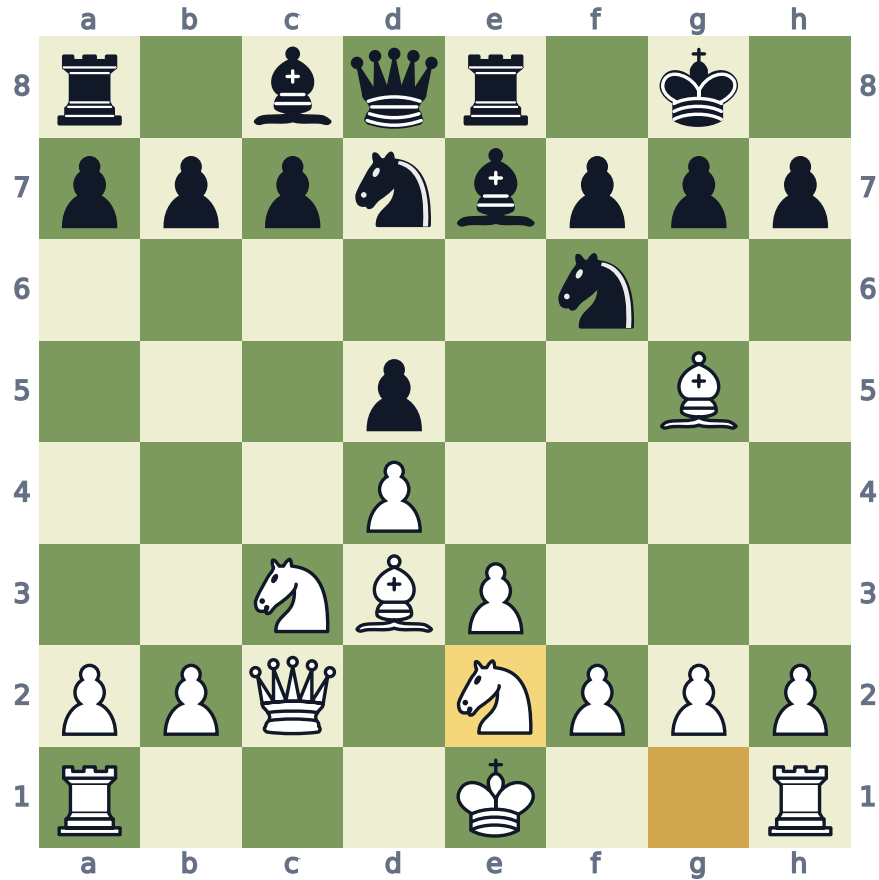
- | | | |
|-----------|-------------------------------------|--|
| 01 | Exchange QGD core | cxd5 plus ...exd5 creates the Carlsbad structure. |
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| 02 | Development before expansion | Ask whether Black's c8 bishop can leave before ...Nbd7. |
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| 03 | Minority attack setup | When Black has a6-b7-c6 versus a2-b2, b4-b5 is the structural lever. |
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 | | |
| 04 | Central expansion setup | Nge2 leaves the f-pawn free and supports c3/e3. |
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 | | |
| 05 | Ragozin treatment | If ...Bb4 appears, recalculate e4 and d5 tactics. |
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 | | |
| 06 | Tarrasch Defense | ...c5 before ...Nf6 often signals the Tarrasch IQP. |
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 | | |
| 07 | Semi-Tarrasch | ...Nxd5 instead of ...exd5 changes the structure completely. |
|
 | | |
| 08 | Orthodox pressure | Rc1 aligns with c6 and prepares efficient c4 recovery. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Exchange QGD core



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2

WHITE'S IDEA

Build toward f3 and e4 or a queenside minority attack.

MAIN DANGER

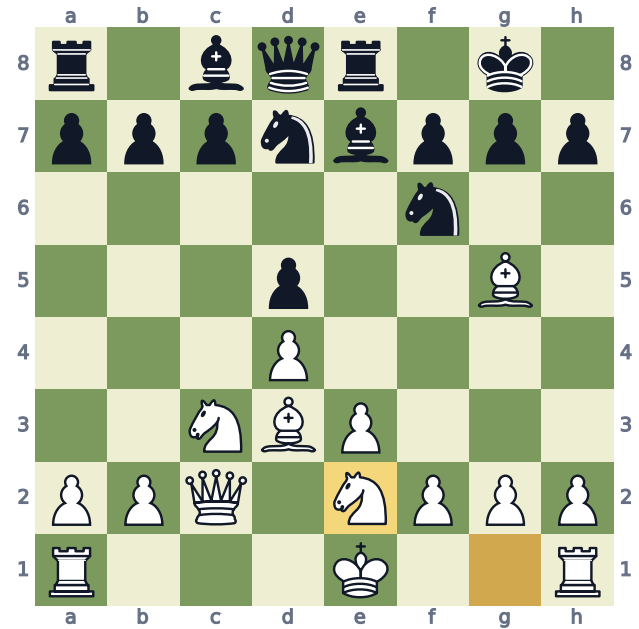
Do not play e4 until d4 and the king are secure.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

cx d5 plus ...ex d5 creates the Carlsbad structure.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

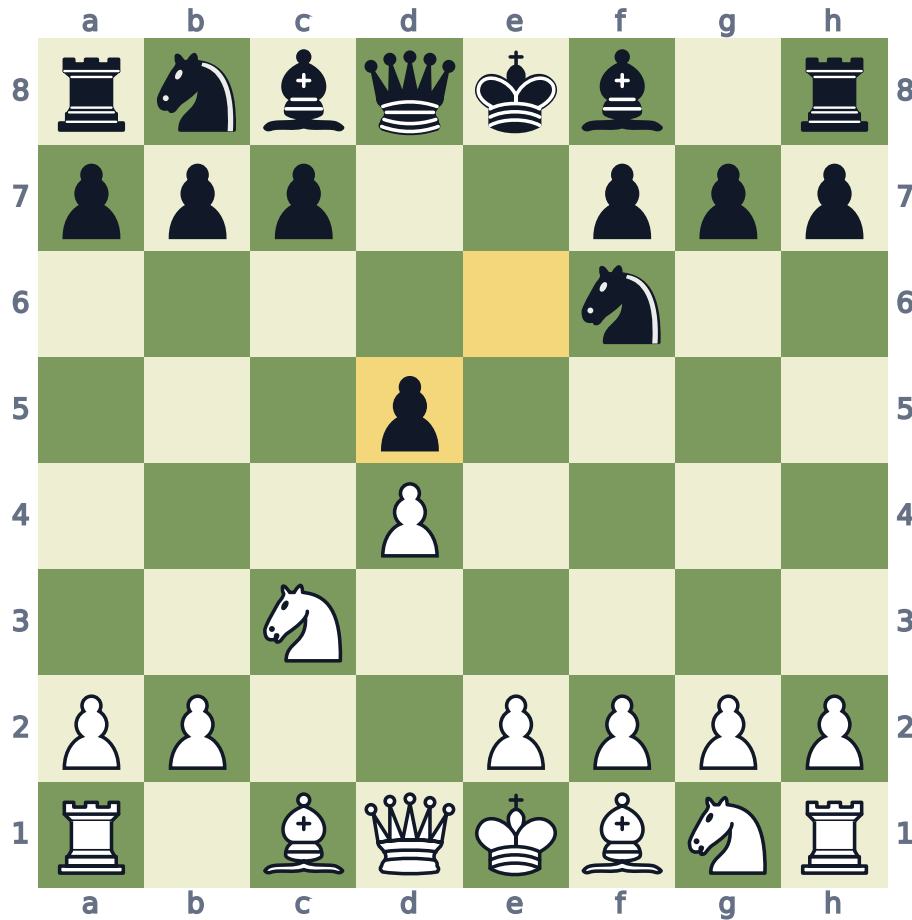
Position estimate: +0.22 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. c6 O-O 2. h6 Bh4 3. Nh5 Bxe7 4. Qxe7 Rae1 5. Ndf6 h3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Exchange QGD core



YOUR TASK

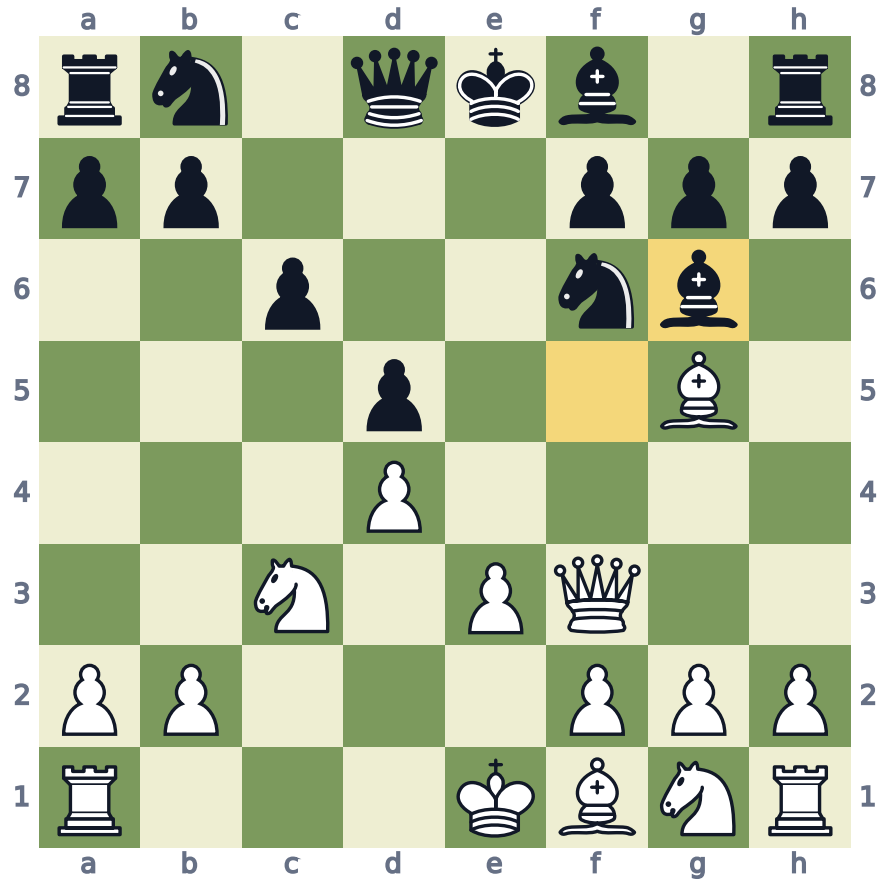
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Development before expansion



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 c6 6. e3 Bf5 7. Qf3 Bg6

WHITE'S IDEA

Prevent a free ...Bf5 or use queen pressure to question the bishop.

MAIN DANGER

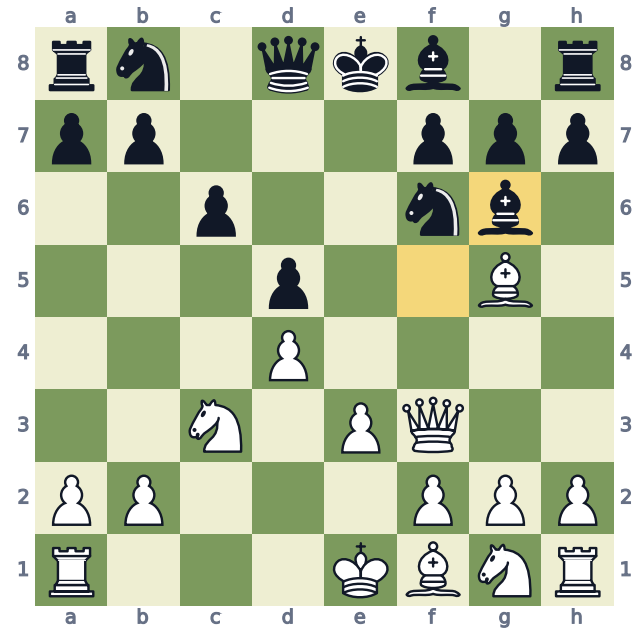
Qf3 can be met by development with tempo if played carelessly.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Ask whether Black's c8 bishop can leave before ...Nbd7.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.38 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bxf6 Qxf6 2. Qxf6 gxf6 3. h4 h5 4. Rc1 Nd7 5. Nh3 Bd6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Development before expansion



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Minority attack setup



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 c6 9. Nge2 Re8 10. O-O Nf8 11. Rab1 a5 12. a3

WHITE'S IDEA

Prepare b4-b5 to create a backward c6-pawn.

MAIN DANGER

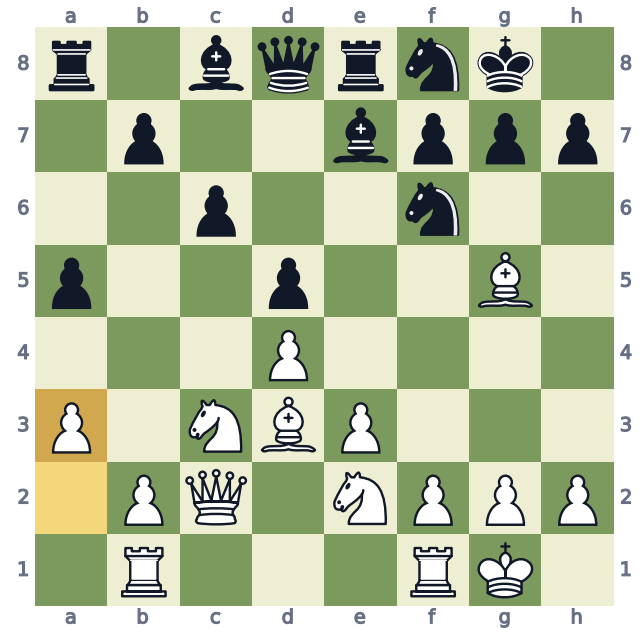
Queenside play must not ignore Black's kingside or central break.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 10 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When Black has a6-b7-c6 versus a2-b2, b4-b5 is the structural lever.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

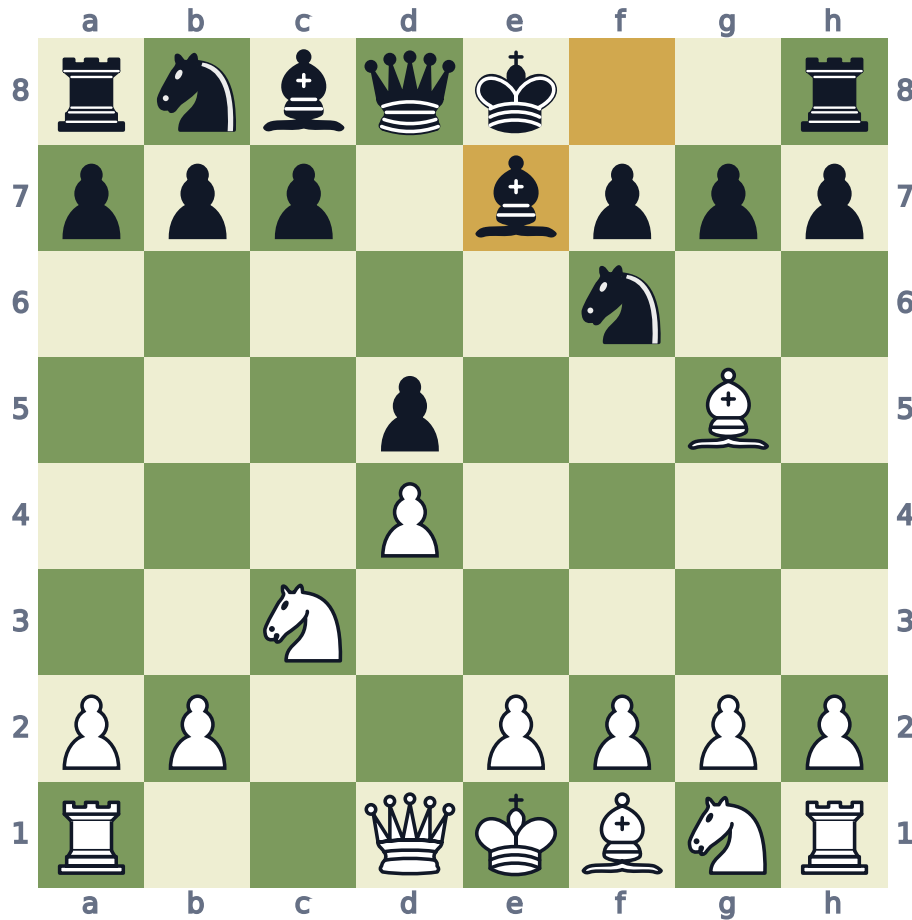
Position estimate: +0.18 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. g6 Nf4 2. Ne6 Nxe6 3. Bxe6 Rfe1 4. Nh5 Bxe7 5. Rxe7 Na4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Minority attack setup



YOUR TASK

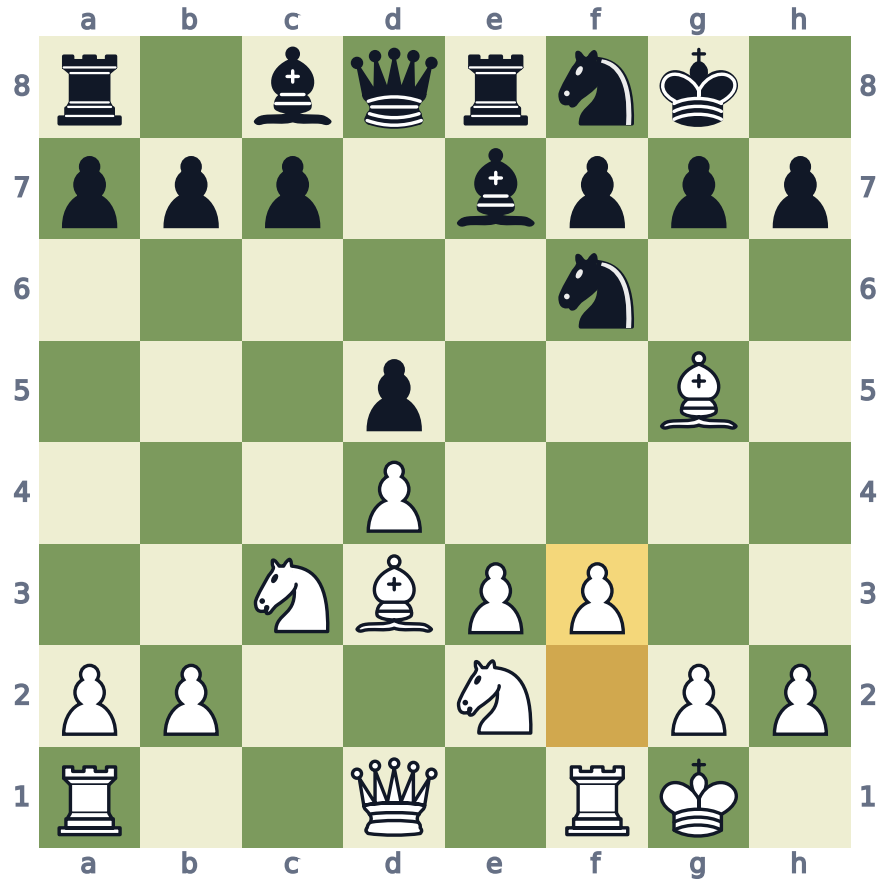
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Central expansion setup



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Nge2 Re8 9. O-O Nf8 10. f3

WHITE'S IDEA

Prepare e4 with pieces and pawns coordinated behind it.

MAIN DANGER

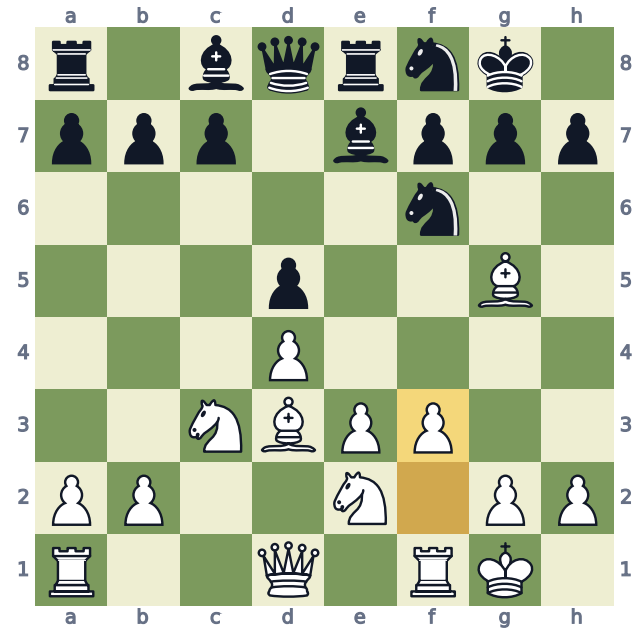
f3 weakens dark squares and costs time; calculate ...c5.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Nge2 leaves the f-pawn free and supports c3/e3.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

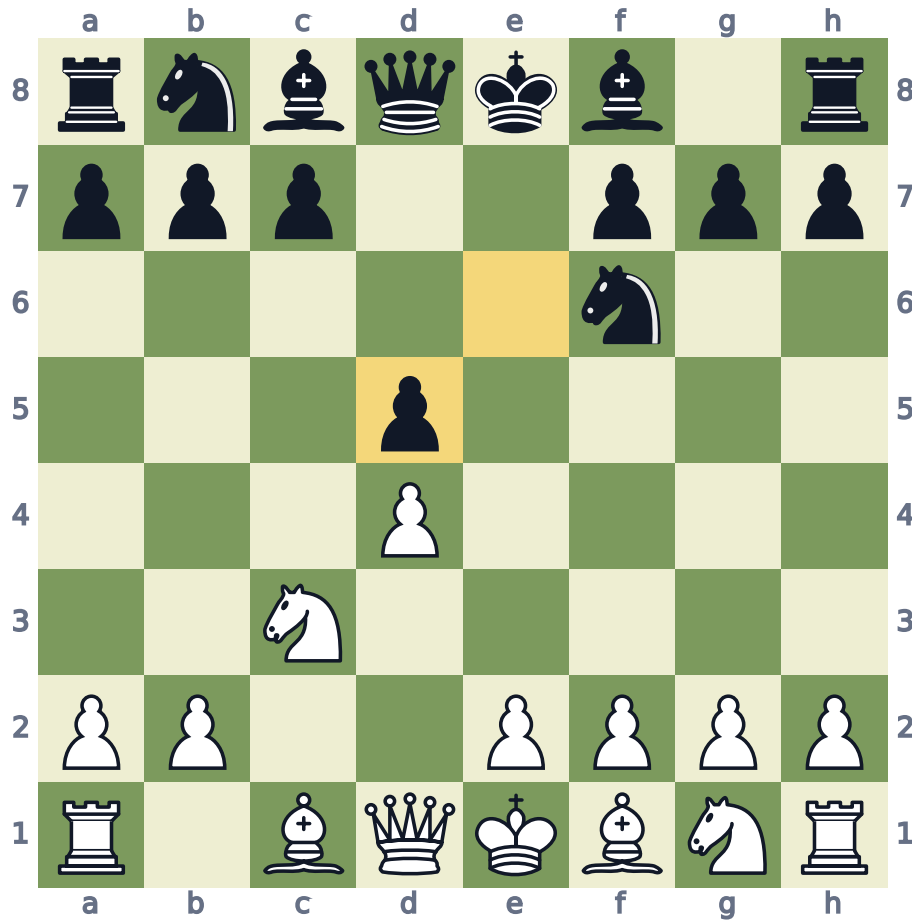
Position estimate: +0.31 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. c5 Bb5 2. Bd7 Bxd7 3. N8xd7 dxc5 4. h6 Bxf6 5. Nxf6 Qd4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Central expansion setup



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Ragozin treatment



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Bb4 6. e3 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. Bd3

WHITE'S IDEA

Use the exchange structure while meeting the pin without panic.

MAIN DANGER

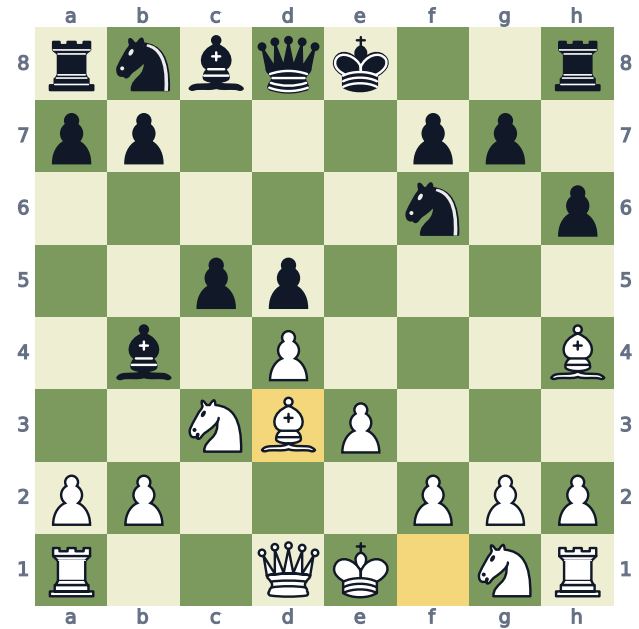
The c3-knight may be pinned when central captures occur.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

If ...Bb4 appears, recalculate e4 and d5 tactics.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.29 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. cxd4 exd4 2. O-O Ne2 3. Be7 O-O 4. Nc6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Ragozin treatment



YOUR TASK

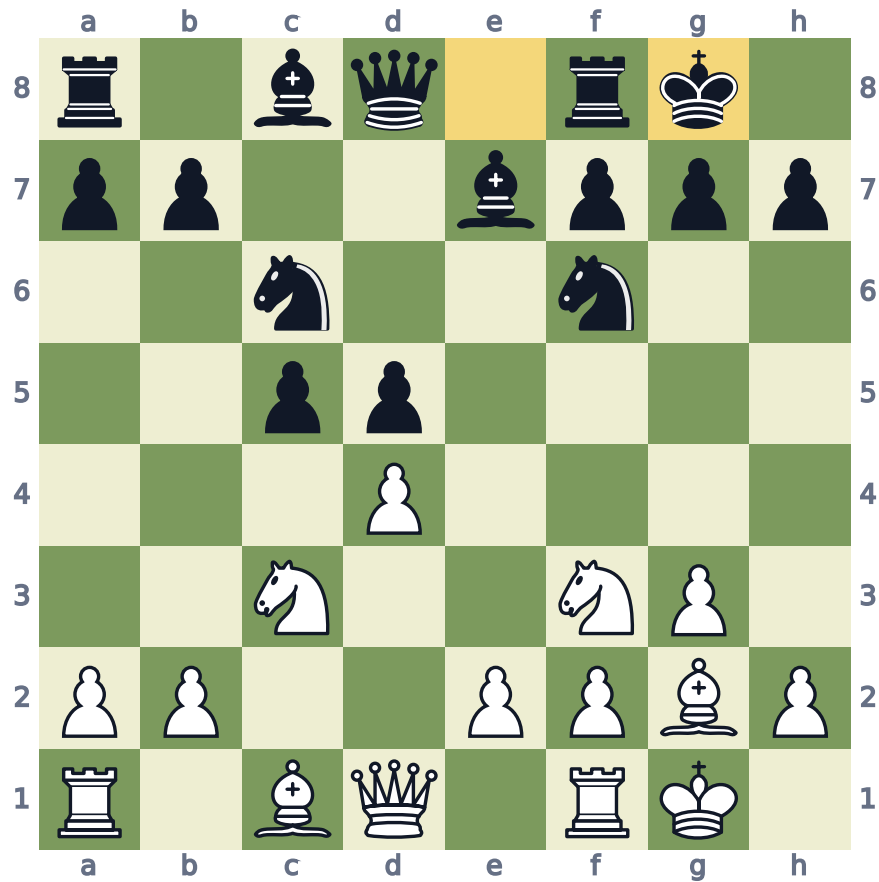
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Tarrasch Defense



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

Pressure the isolated d5-pawn while finishing development.

MAIN DANGER

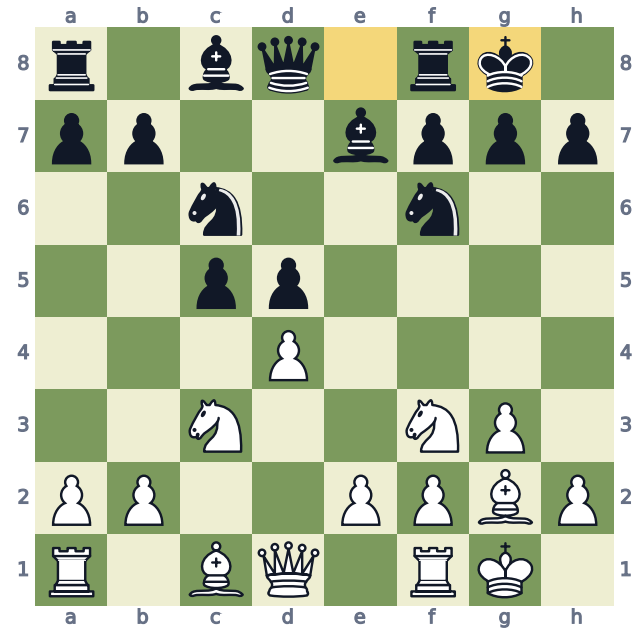
Passive blockade lets Black use active piece play as compensation.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...c5 before ...Nf6 often signals the Tarrasch IQP.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

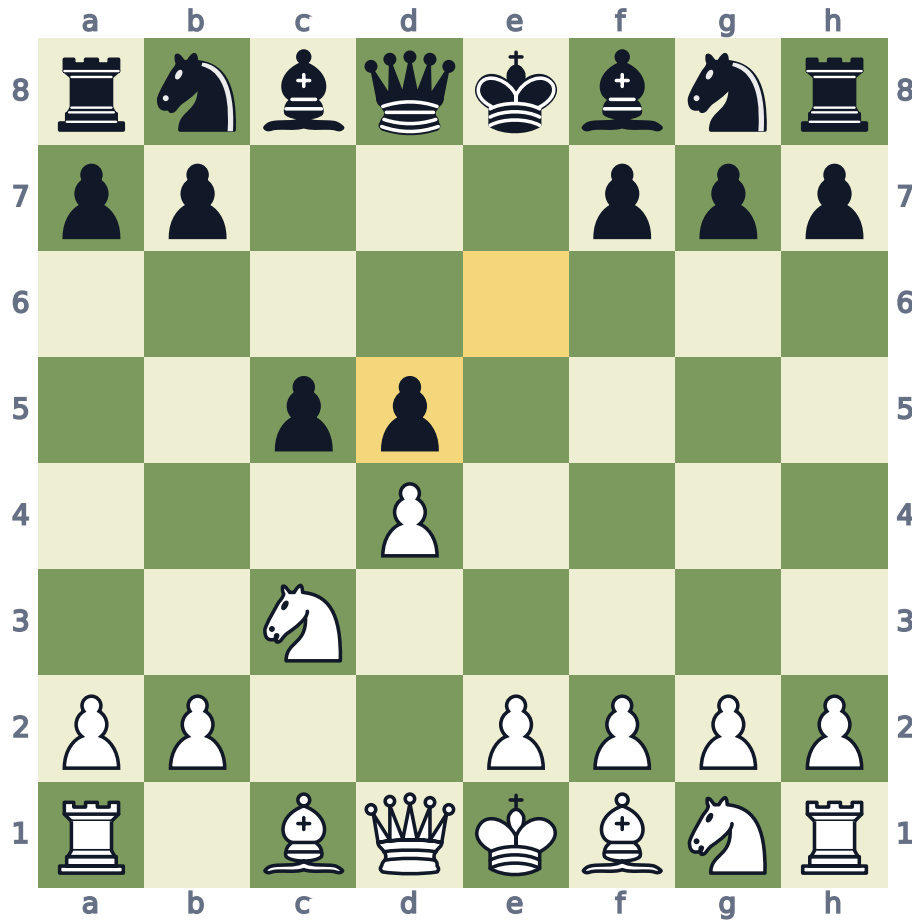
Position estimate: +0.53 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bg5 c4 2. Ne5 Be6 3. e3 h6 4. Bxf6 Bxf6 5. f4 Bxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Tarrasch Defense



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Semi-Tarrasch



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. Nf3 c5 6. e3 Nc6 7. Bd3

WHITE'S IDEA

Develop around a flexible center and prepare to isolate or exchange Black's d-pawn.

MAIN DANGER

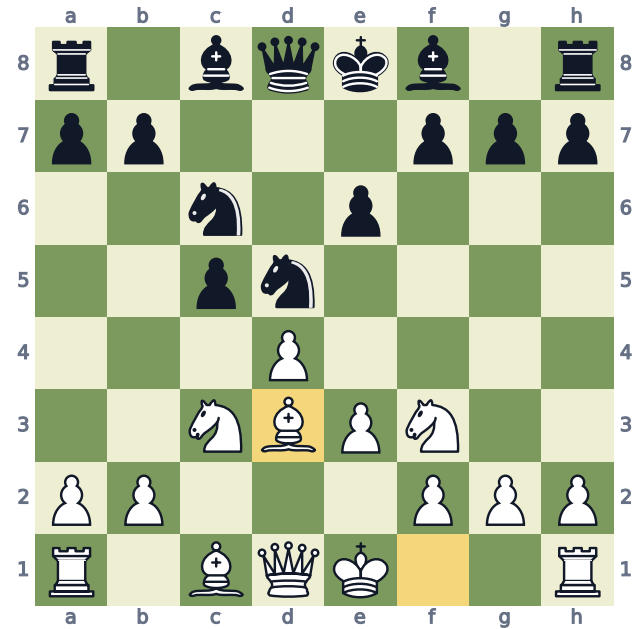
The symmetrical center can open suddenly after ...cxd4.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Nxd5 instead of ...exd5 changes the structure completely.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. cxd4 exd4 2. Bb4 Bd2 3. Nf6 a3 4. Be7 Be3 5. O-O O-O

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Semi-Tarrasch



YOUR TASK

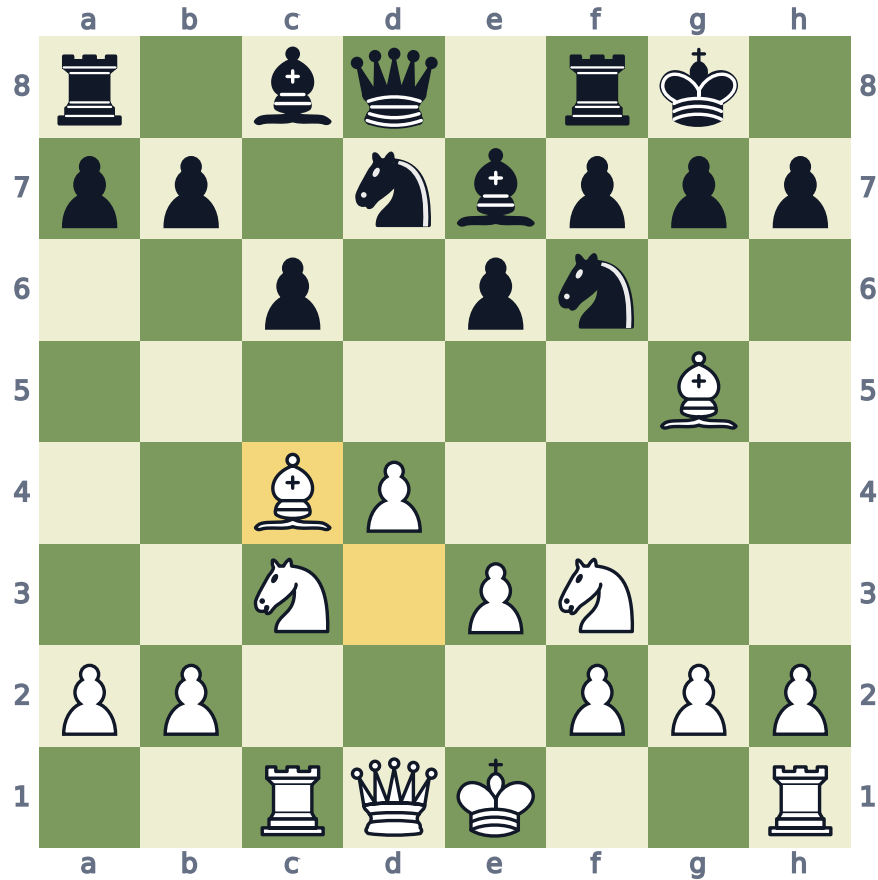
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

Orthodox pressure



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4

WHITE'S IDEA

Use development and c-file pressure before deciding the central structure.

MAIN DANGER

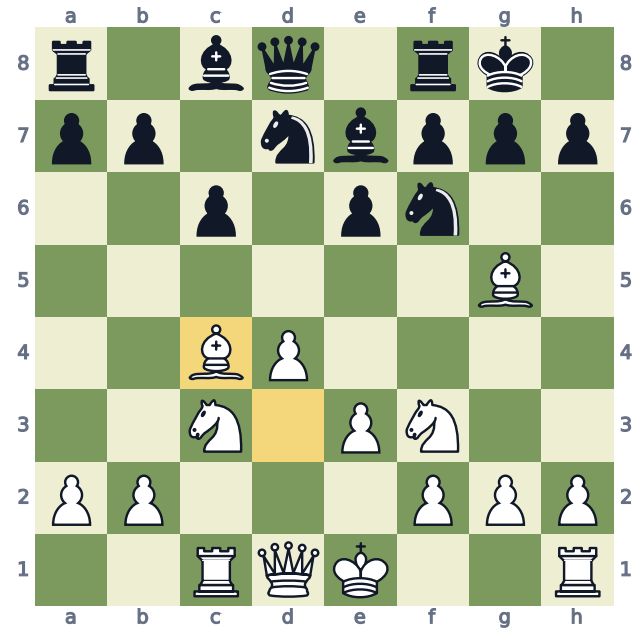
Maintaining tension forever can allow Black to free the game.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Rc1 aligns with c6 and prepares efficient c4 recovery.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.22 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a6 Be2 2. b5 Ne5 3. Bb7 Nxd7 4. Qxd7

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

Orthodox pressure



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. EXCHANGE QGD CORE

Course move: Bg5. Purpose: Build toward f3 and e4 or a queenside minority attack. Engine comparison: 1. Bg5 Be7 2. e3 O-O 3. Bd3 c5 4. Nge2 c4 (+0.30 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Do not play e4 until d4 and the king are secure.

02. DEVELOPMENT BEFORE EXPANSION

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Prevent a free ...Bf5 or use queen pressure to question the bishop. Engine comparison: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Qf3 can be met by development with tempo if played carelessly.

03. MINORITY ATTACK SETUP

Course move: e3. Purpose: Prepare b4-b5 to create a backward c6-pawn. Engine comparison: 1. e3 h6 2. Bh4 Bf5 3. Bxf6 Bxf6 4. Qb3 c5 5. Nge2 Be6 (+0.33 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Queenside play must not ignore Black's kingside or central break.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. CENTRAL EXPANSION SETUP

Course move: Bg5. Purpose: Prepare e4 with pieces and pawns coordinated behind it. Engine comparison: 1. Bg5 Be7 2. e3 O-O 3. Bd3 c5 4. Nge2 c4 (+0.30 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: f3 weakens dark squares and costs time; calculate ...c5.

05. RAGOZIN TREATMENT

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Use the exchange structure while meeting the pin without panic. Engine comparison: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The c3-knight may be pinned when central captures occur.

06. TARRASCH DEFENSE

Course move: Nf3. Purpose: Pressure the isolated d5-pawn while finishing development. Engine comparison: 1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 Be7 (+0.50 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Passive blockade lets Black use active piece play as compensation.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. SEMI-TARRASCH

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Develop around a flexible center and prepare to isolate or exchange Black's d-pawn. Engine comparison: 1. Bg5 dxc4 2. e4 c5 3. d5 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The symmetrical center can open suddenly after ...cxd4.

08. ORTHODOX PRESSURE

Course move: e3. Purpose: Use development and c-file pressure before deciding the central structure. Engine comparison: 1. e3 O-O 2. Nf3 Nbd7 3. a3 h6 4. Bh4 dxc4 5. Bxc4 a6 (+0.27 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Maintaining tension forever can allow Black to free the game.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.